

Baboquivari, Kino, and Ajo: Three Long Days in Arizona

When: October 21st to 23rd, 2011

Where: Southern Arizona

Who: Jack Kieffer & Rudy Fleck

Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157627969877926/>

Videos (courtesy of Rudy Fleck):

Baboquivari: <http://youtu.be/Md7sfx78Wl8>

Kino: <http://youtu.be/2TnE-V6hAd4>

GPS Track:

Baboquivari: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/6301631273/in/set-72157627969877926>

Kino: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/6301631591/in/set-72157627969877926>

Ajo: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/6302157904/in/set-72157627969877926>

Baboquivari was another one of those peaks that get talked about as a technically difficult and generally fun climb. Being one of the few remaining 4th class DPS peaks I hadn't already climbed Jack and I decided we'd make it a priority as soon as desert season rolled around again.

So with AMP behind us and the Sierras starting to get snow we set off for a long haul out to southern Arizona cleanout the three peaks located along the southern border: Baboquivari, Ajo, and Kino. The always agreeable Rudy Fleck decided to join us.

We left Orange County at 4 pm for the 8+ hour drive to the desert southwest of Tucson.

It was a long drive. We took the 5 down to San Diego then jumped on the 8 east into Arizona and eventually split off into the middle of nowhere.

Along the way we ran in to towns named things like...



Interestingly enough my theory of how the town had been named (basically "We're settling here? Why? Oh God Why?") was actually incorrect. Turns out it was due to the fact the 85 and 86 used had a Y intersection there and Arizona law required a three letter name for any town. I like my explanation better.

After many more miles we turned off on a dirt road towards Baboquivari Camp. This road went on a good 9+ miles and we saw several wild javelina running around on the road ahead of us. They took off into the brush before we could get pictures but look like this.



They can also be rather aggressive apparently but fortunately I was sleeping in by vehicle with Jack and Rudy outside standing guard.

As I told Anne via text that night

“Bad news is there are wild pigs around. Good news is that I’m inside. Bad news is Rudy and Jack are sleeping outside. Good news is that I have an axe so I may be able to turn their mauling into my organic bacon breakfast.”

Sadly we had an uneventful night.

Saturday: Baboquivari The Nipple-less God of Mischief

We had pulled in sometime after 1 in the morning and quickly fallen asleep. We woke up with the sun and went about getting ready.



It was actually a rather nice campground with fire pits and structures made out on ocotillo scattered around. We had it to ourselves except for one other vehicle further in that looked to be another group of climbers.





There was even a bathroom with flush toilets.



We could see Baboquivari from camp looking rather more dramatic for the clouds hitting it.

Per Wikipedia:

Baboquivari Peak is the most sacred place to the Tohono O’odham people. It is the center of the Tohono O’odham cosmology and the home of the creator, [I’toi](#). According to tribal legend, he resides in a cave below the base of the mountain.

This mountain is regarded by the O’odham nation as the navel of the world — a place where the earth opened and the people emerged after the great flood. Baboquivari Peak is also sometimes referred to as I’toi Mountain. In the native O'odham language, it is referred to as **Waw Kiwulik**, meaning "narrow about the middle". The O'odham people believe that he watches over their people to this day.



The trail starts out well defined.



Soon after this we lost the trail for a time and ended up bushwhacking up the slope until we found it again.



Later we ran into some folks who had been there multiple times before and they said that this was the first time they'd managed not to get lost down below. That made me feel a bit better.

Once we were back on the trail it was much more straightforward though slightly overgrown.



It was also starting to get a bit warm. The weather was predicting temperatures somewhere in the 90s.





The trail eventually led us to the start of the interesting section.



This is the Great Ramp. Off to the left where Jack and I were it was somewhat interesting but Rudy stuck to the right and managed to keep it class 2 the entire way.





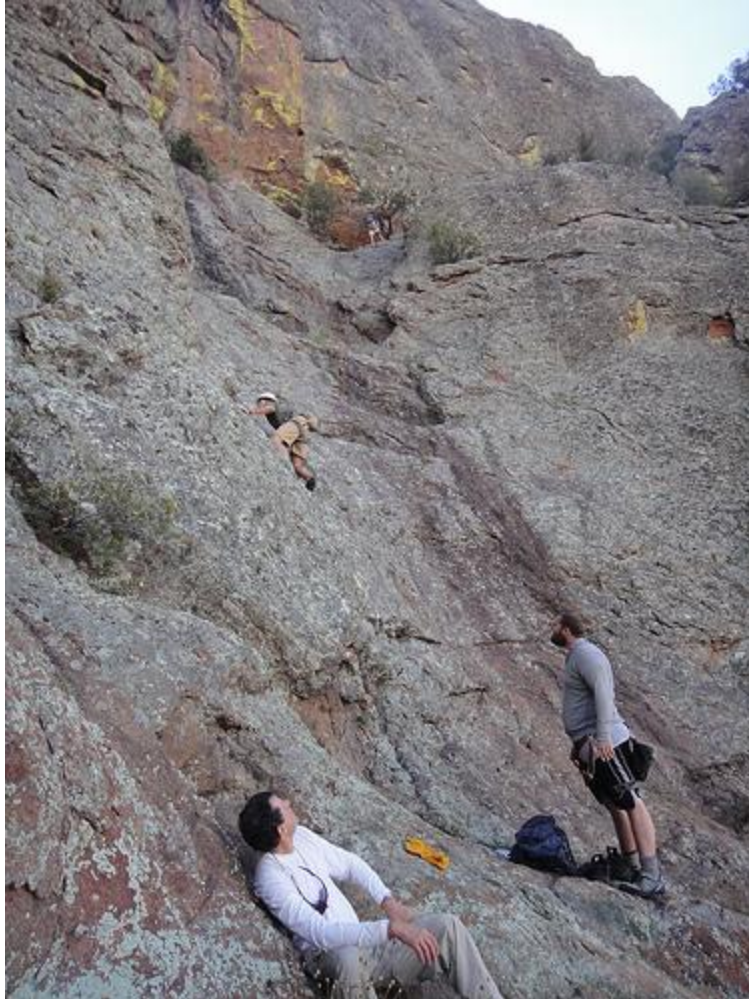
There was debris from the old staircase back when there was a fire lookout on the top but nothing useful.



Past that the brush was a bit thicker and we came to the crux.



One small single rope section with fairly trivial climbing, two bolts, and a pair of hangers at the top to build an anchor. Welcome to back country sport climbing...



We ran into the climbers from below on the pitch and took the opportunity to get our gear on and heat with them while they finished up.



Rudy noticed these tiny shoes in a hole in the rock. Looks like an offering to the mountain god from someone who didn't want to climb the last bit.



Despite my gimped status from my recent fall in the Sierras I managed to limp up the pitch and belay the others from the top.

Per the DPS guide we had a second rope along but it turns out the top anchor has been moved down some time ago so we only ever used one.

A short scramble later we made the summit. (There is one place where we almost climbed up some sketchy low 5th rock with a questionably placed sling anchor but we poked around and found the actual trail continued past.)



Up top we found a cairn complete with the usual register and a collection of offerings left by past climbers for good luck.





(Bivy and condoms)



(Drug paraphernalia of some sort)



(See thru photos of impregnated lady bits)



(Bag of random kiddy stuff plus picture)



(Body studs of some sort)

(I chose to believe it was a nipple stud and henceforth insisted on referring to Baboquivari as the Nipple-less God of Mischief.)



(Random egg thing)

We took a short break and headed down as we planned to relocate closer to Kino that night.



The single pitch was the only real obstacle. Jack set up the rope and did the ever manly and painful dulfersitz rappel.



We recovered the rope and continued down. This time we stuck to the 2nd class bit of the Great Ramp.



Then it was just the trail.





Anyone lose a cow?





We had some last glances of Babo as we made the car with maybe an hour to go before sunset.

The original plan called for relocating to the trailhead for Kino that night but after discussing our options and worries about being in the middle of nowhere near the border we decided to stay where we were and drive over pre dawn. After all we had the campground to ourselves and it would be a shame to waste it.

So we went about cooking dinner, setting up our sleeping bags...



Father Fleck found an axe to wield.



And Jack started us a campfire.

Despite the heat earlier the night was spectacular.

Day 2: Kino Peak



We had a good long drive to get to Kino so I had us up well before dawn. We made our coffee, loaded up, and got on the road.



We arrived at the outskirts of Ajo just as it was getting light. The most interesting feature was a very large mining pit.



Here we turned down a dirt road and entered Organ Pipe National Monument. This friendly sign greets you:



This goes into my collection of comforting signs right along with “Bombing Range: Objects May Fall From Airplanes” and various warnings about unexploded ordinance laying around the Boise foothills.



There was actually a fee station way down the dirt road. My park pass had us covered but we filled out a tag and left it.



The DPS A route starts at a small homestead called Bates Well. We stopped there briefly and poked around the open structure.



Instead of parking at Bates itself we went a bit further down the road which put us flat in the middle of a large wash heading towards our peak.



There was no sign of anyone around. I was somewhat concerned about leaving my vehicle after Rudy related that someone had had their car broken in to while doing this peak years ago. We tried to hide any sign of valuables, water, or coolers and set off hoping it would still be there when we returned.

We set out across the desert and soon came across multiple clearly established footpaths.



All the footsteps seemed to be heading north and there were countless discarded water bottles and bits of clothing.



We could see our peak as we approached a wide flat saddle.



And it was hot. We'd had a bit of a break weather-wise the day before but today it was in the mid to upper 90s.



Once at the saddle we made a hard right and started climbing.



We found multiple ducks along the way.





We did get off route a bit when we climbed to the top of the initial ridge. This left us having to down climb a somewhat sketchy bit covered in overly friendly cactus.



Once down that we crossed a shallow saddle and started up what first appeared to be an un-climbable face.

Around this time we had a border patrol helicopter buzz past us to the west but it didn't seem to notice us.



Once across we could see a slightly loose route across and up. I heard later there'd been a fall resulting in a broken leg here years ago.



Once up top we signed in. Not too surprisingly there weren't a huge number of folks out climbing Kino.



It was also so hot we retreated a short distance and hid in the shadow of a rock while we ate lunch.



The descent was unremarkable except for the heat. We were all very happy to find my vehicle waiting for us. I'd been eyeing the liter or so of water I had left thinking about what we'd do if someone had stolen or trashed it...



On the way out we did find this one tiny lone sign at Bates Well warning us not to go more than 100 yards into the backcountry. Oops.

We ate a so-so dinner in Ajo at a restaurant with several javalina running around in the parking lot and drove south to a campground a few miles north of the border.

Sunday: Ajo And Another Long Drive

One bathroom scorpion, one ambulance running towards the border lights blazing, and two low altitude helicopter buzzing later we managed to get a few hours of sleep in the campground across the road from the Ajo trailhead.



Ajo was the easiest of the three peaks and we were all looking forward to getting up and back down so we weren't driving half the night.



Ajo is access from a trailhead at the far end of a paved one way loop. There are a number of scenic views along the way.



Ajo is the point in the background.



The hike is all on trail and again the views were quite pretty.



The official trail ends at Bull Pasture but we found a clear use trail all the way to the top.





And it was hot.





There's a radio tower up top with a rather large solar panel attached.



The register is also bolted to the rock as there isn't much protection up there. We had a nice time up there soaking in the view.



The descent felt like it took forever as my knee was swelling up from the last few days of abuse which slowed me down a bit. Eventually we made the car and gratefully changed out of our sweaty hiking clothes.

From there it was just a matter of driving home. This involved maybe 5 border patrol checkpoints and a quick stop in Yuma to eat at a hole in the wall Mexican food place Jack and I had found last year when we climbed Little Picacho.





Not bad for a quick weekend.